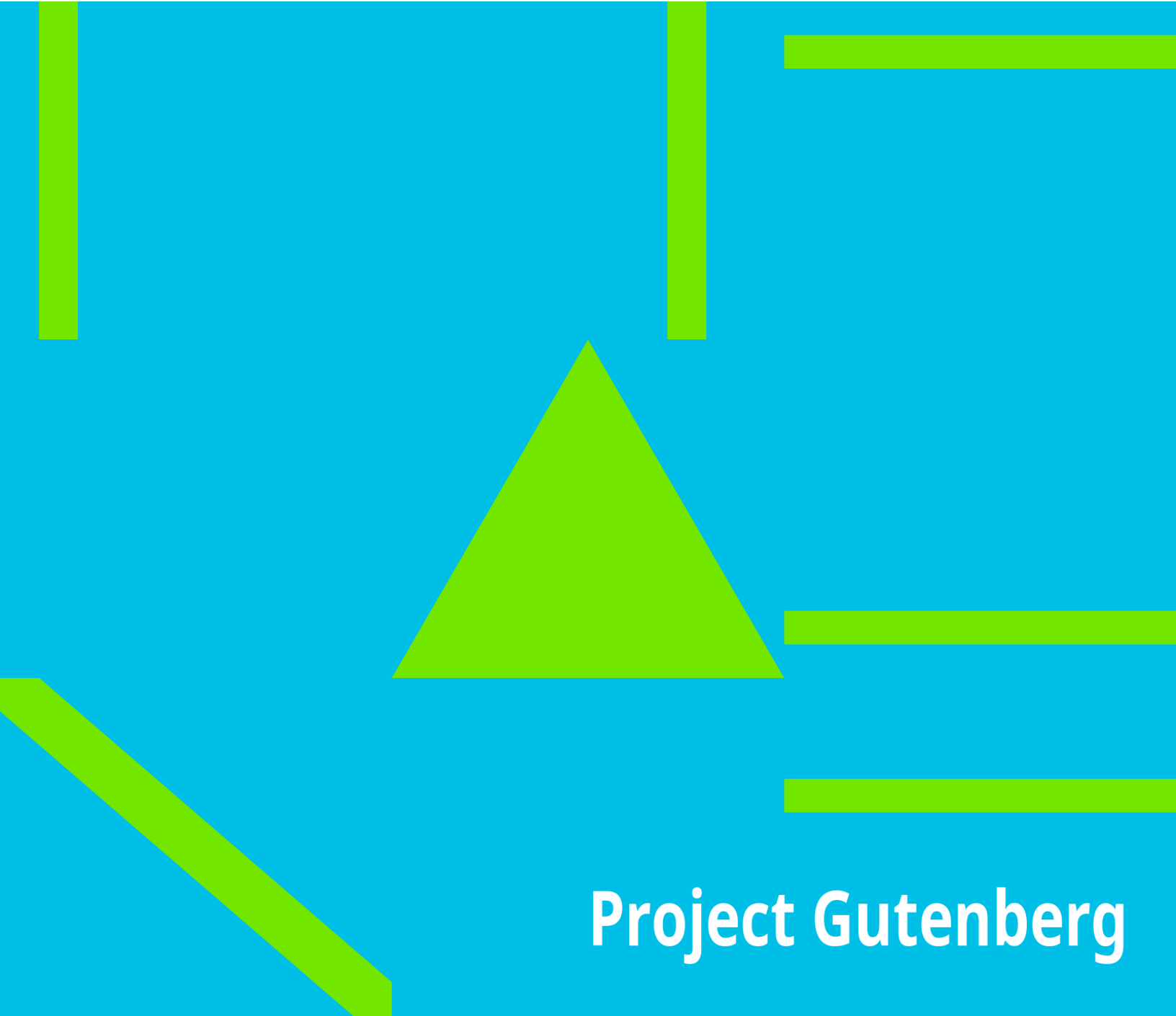


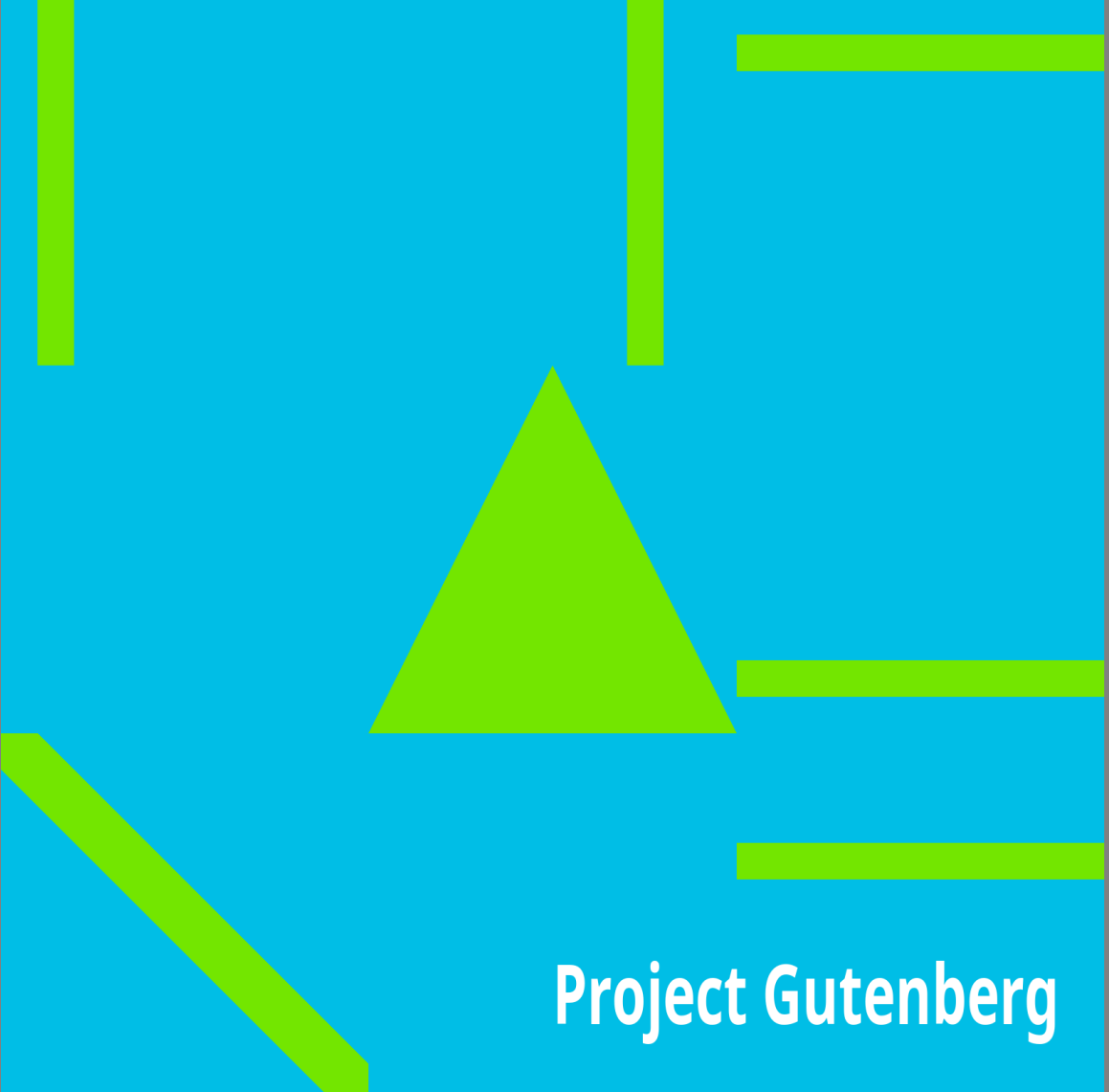
The Arm Chair

Unknown



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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE ARM
CHAIR ***

THE ARM CHAIR.

**"YOUR FATHERS, WHERE ARE THEY? AND THE
PROPHETS, DO THEY LIVE FOREVER?"**

SECOND EDITION.

PHILADELPHIA—1843.

MEMORANDUM.

The history of these rhymes is briefly this.—An Arm Chair, made many years ago by John Letchworth, for Leonard and Jane Snowdon, was presented to the Author, with some information of the worthies who were wont to visit the estimable owners; accompanied with an intimation that it would be a suitable theme for some verses. The result follows.

THE ARM CHAIR.

Cowper, the poet of the Christian
muse,
Sung of the Sofa; could I but infuse
Some of his talent in my laggard quill,
Some of his genius on my verse distil,
Then would I sing,—my theme too from
the fair,—
Of thy coevals, rhyme-creating chair!

He who with artist's skill scooped out
thy seat,
Trim made thy elbows, uprights, and thy
feet,
Now fourscore years and four has
measured o'er,
And waits his summons to the heavenly
shore.
Honest as sunshine, he "who runs may
read,"
That **Letchworth** is "an Israelite indeed;"
No guile within him ever finds a place,
Love of the Father spreads to all the race.
His gospel ministry is void of show,
For "few and savory" are the words that
flow:
Condensed and pithy are his periods
found,

Rich in their matter, nothing for mere
 sound.
So preaches he. Ah, what a sad mistake,
When empty sounds upon the people
 break,
When a stentorian voice in efforts vain,
Roars to the people,—thunder without
 rain!
Its booming echoes may the soul appal,
But no reviving showers on nature fall.
—Would that my age,—if age to me be
 given,—
Might prove like his, who calmly looks to
 heaven,
Waiting with patience for the mandate
 blessed,
"Thy labour finished, enter into rest!"
"Here," said the patriarch, no more
 doomed to range,
"Quiet I lie, waiting my final change."
Go when thou wilt, thy faithful life will
 prove,
A rich example, legacy of love!

Ah, my Arm Chair, supporter of the
 good,
Beneath how many a worthy hast thou
 stood!
Bear me awhile, assist me to portray,
Some of the faithful who have passed
 away.

Here **Harrison**[\[1\]](#) has spoke of what
 she saw
In visions deep, when filled with holy
 awe,
The curtain of the future half withdrew,

While coming objects glided into view;
Or as the past on memory's tablet rose,
Rehearsed her gospel joys, her gospel
woes.

Told how King George, as gushed the
hidden springs,
Bowed at her message from the King of
kings;

Of deep probations for her Lord she past;
Of her fond hope of joining him at last.
Told how her soul, in sympathy, had long
Borne a deep burthen for the negro's
wrong,

'Till the church freed her at her Master's
will,

In southern states love's purpose to fulfil.
With gospel power for Truth and right she
spoke,

'Till slumbering consciences to feeling
woke,

Oppressors' hearts with justice learned to
beat,

While bondmen's shackles fell beneath
their feet.

Her's was a righteous mission; to the door
Of selfish masters she her message bore;
She shot no fiery missiles from afar,
Kindling those feelings that engender war,
But face to face Truth's message would
impart,

Whilst love-tipped arrows entered many a
heart;

Thus won she freedom for the sore
oppressed;

Her work was honoured and her labour
blessed.

—Or as the present did her thoughts
engage,
Gave to her juniors dear-bought counsel
sage.
Bade her loved niece preserve in vessel
pure,
Her sacred gift, and make her calling sure;
Bade her true partner as an Aaron be,
Uphold her hands, support her ministry.
Full well dear **Leonard** thou that charge
redeemed;
When through her heart the gospel current
streamed,
In secret labour was thy spirit found,
While trembling forth she sent the gospel
sound;
A very Quaker,—as she gave the law
Her outward motion spoke her inward
awe.

Here **Scattergood**, when evening came
at length,
From the day's toil reposed his weary
strength;
From Christian sympathy that solace
drew,
Which those can grant who heavenly joys
pursue.
Mournful of spirit, he was ever found,
In sympathy with souls by sorrow bound.
As fell his plaintive voice upon the ear,
The poor in spirit felt a friend was near.
Prompt in his duty at the house of prayer,
To plead with fervour for his Master there,
While crowds hung trembling on that
zealous tongue,
Which only woke as living waters sprung.

He never preached himself,—his every
word
Directed to a slain and risen Lord.
He to the weary consolation brought,
He for the burthened sweet deliverance
wrought;
Though bound himself, the fettered oft set
free,—
The Jeremiah of his age was he!

Savery has here oft passed a friendly
hour,
Feeling of sympathy the magic power,
As heart to heart the secret influence sent,
—
As prayer ascended where no knee was
bent,—
As for each other's welfare sighs were
given,—
Unclothed with words, their wishes
entering heaven.
The Indians' friend, he sought their native
wood,
An anxious labourer for the redman's
good;
Beside the lake, beneath the spreading
tree,
His gospel message flowed as Truth set
free.

Here too has sat,—like him of stature
small,
Great too of heart,—a minister like Paul,
—
One who, obedient to his Master's will,
Was studious found his duty to fulfil.

Six times went **Emlen**^[2] o'er the Atlantic
wave,

On gospel errands sinful man to save,
And still returning from his work of love,
Came with his olive-branch and peaceful
dove.

Though years rolled on and outward sight
grew dim,

The lamp of Truth still brightly burned
with him,

Showing distinctly in its searching light,
Deeds that the actors deemed were hid in
night.

His urim and his thummim was with God,
And he obedient to his Master's nod.
As secret feeling told him of distress,
The sufferer's door-sill soon his foot
would press.

Thus Mercy led,—and pleasantly he said,
That he "by jobbing earned his daily
bread."

Ah, these were luscious morsels, ate with
joy,

A heavenly relish free from all alloy;
Some of that bread of which the righteous
eat,

That others know not of,—sustaining
meat.

Here too **Rebecca Jones** sweet
converse sought.

With friends in unison of faith and
thought;

With both of whom in gospel yoke she
knew

To labour as her Lord and Master drew.
Honest of purpose,—ardent in reproof

To those who stood from duty's path
aloof,—
In public gatherings or in private hall,
To warn the giddy of impending fall,—
Rebuke the forward,—lead the fearful
where
A mighty Rock did Israel's Lord prepare,
—
Instant in duty,—though severe, yet kind,
She showed the vigour of a heaven-led
mind.

Of ardent temper, quick and flashing
zeal,
Keen as high polished but too brittle steel,
In earlier life **James Cresson** had been
found,
Like a high steed when first in harness
bound;
But grace had tempered, and obedience
wrought,
A change of character in word and
thought,
His ardent feelings felt love's holy calm,
Fitting a follower of the lowly Lamb.

A pointing finger to none other shown,
A secret whisper to none other known,
Bade **Arthur Howell** hasten on his way,
Where a secluded country grave-yard lay.
A few sad mourners stood beside a grave,
Where "dust to dust" a solemn language
gave.
Soon from his lips burst forth the ardent
strain—
"I know not who this coffin may contain,

"But my good Master, in whose power I
came,
"Now bids me clear from wrong an
injured name.
"She who now rests within this narrow
bed,
"By slander wounded bowed her
sorrowing head;
"Accused of that, in which she had no
part,
"She died in innocence—a broken heart!"
—As from a stranger came these words, a
thrill
Of secret, wondering joy, the mourners
fill;
For she who died, told, as approached her
end,
That God a witness to her grave would
send,
Who to her innocence should boldly bear,
A clear, convincing testimony there.
And He whose ways are wrapt in mystery
still,
Blindfold his servant led to do his will!
—Oft to the grave this servant of the
Lord,
Was sent to preach the everlasting Word;
To rouse the thoughtless from delusion's
dream,
Memento mori was his frequent theme.

When Pestilence her raven wing
outspread,
When terror swept the living from the
dead,—
When love's own ties were severed in
affright,

And duty's call had lost its wonted might,

—

Offley and others, a devoted band,
Before the march of terror took their
stand.

They nobly dared in that dark hour to
make

Themselves an offering for the people's
sake.

He was accepted! Great the church's loss,
She mourned a faithful champion of the
cross,

Gathered at mid-day—soon the race was
won,—

Long e'er the evening shades his labour
done!

—Two of the worthies linger of that day

—

Letchworth and **Wistar**—hastening fast
away.

Shrewd, witty, eloquent,—with ample
store

Of all that schools could give of classic
lore,

Sarcastic powers opposing views to chill,
When such the purpose of his subtle will,

—

A learned lawyer, **Nicholas Wain** could
sway,

A jury's feelings in his youthful day;

But soon, like Paul, when the unseen One
spoke,

Humble he bowed and bore the Christian
yoke;

Gamaliel's lessons ceasing to repeat,
He lay a learner at the Saviour's feet.

Simple of heart, and of a feeble frame,
Feeling unworthy even Christ to name,
Yet raised by Him of living hopes to tell,
And show his power,—himself a miracle,

James Simpson, like his Lord, from
things around,
Fit subjects for important lessons found;
A cloud o'erspreading, or a bird on wing,
Would to the theme in hand instruction
bring.
Filled by his Master wonderously he
shone,
His emptied vessel scarce could stand
alone!

Slow as a traveller wends o'er miry
ways,
Whose prudent care his onward course
delays,
So **Richard Jordan** preached; at first
each word
Came slowly forth, nor life nor feeling
stirred;
But soon, the channel cleared, the rippling
flow,
In freer volume swifter currents show;
Bolder and higher then it gathers force,
A mountain torrent rushing down its
course;
So **Jordan** ministered in life's mid-day,
A Boanerges thundering on his way!

Bacons and **Wilson**s,[\[3\]](#) worthies not a
few,
Touched by love's magnet, hither often
drew;

Smith, with his venerable locks of snow,
Sedately cautious the right path to know;
Devoted ministers, alas! no more,
And worthy elders who the ark once bore.
—When these were gone,—their bodies to
the sod,
Their spirits taken to their fixed abode,
A cloud around our Israel's camp arose,
While from our firesides started up our
foes;
When a bold infidel his poison spread,
And with his scorpions hungry children
fed;—
Another race, part of the by-gone age,
Yet of the present, then employed the
stage.

When boding mists had gathering force
and form,
Ruth Richardson was taken from the
storm.
True to her Master she was free to die,
Yet nature shrank from the last agony:
Gladly would she have left this scene of
pain,
The promised kingdom of her Lord to
gain,
But awful feelings shadowed forth the
strife,
The dread concomitant of parting life.
Gently her spirit from its house of clay,
Was sent on wings of mercy on its way.
When came the pale-faced messenger to
free,
Her eyes were holden that she did not see.
No pain—no sorrow—e'en her evening
prayer,

Joined with her morning hymn of glory
there.

She felt no agony of parting breath,
Taken in kindness without tasting death!

Melodious singer of heart-thrilling
songs,

Of Zion's injuries and Israel's wrongs,
Whose lonely harp still on the willow
hung,

Till fresh-felt mercies every chord
restrung;

Then touched to praise its tones in
sweetness broke,

That in each heart responsive feelings
woke!

—Oh, I behold thee, as I last beheld,
When gospel love thy grateful bosom
swelled,—

When weeping listeners heard the tale of
woe,

Of mental conflicts it was thine to know,
—

When as a flood the enemy came in,
Sweeping away the barriers against sin,—
When from a pit of horror burst thy moan,
Illumined by no brightness from the
throne,—

When sombre shadows compassed thee
around,—

When satan's legions pierced with many a
wound,—

When the rank weeds were wrapp'd about
thy head,—

When boisterous billows over thee were
spread,—

Then He who died and triumphed o'er the
grave,
Arose in might thy struggling soul to save;
Bade the waves sunder and temptations
fly,
The scattering clouds haste from the
brightening sky,
The sun of righteousness with cheering
ray,
Shed the full radiance of perfected day.
—Then from thy lips poured forth a joyful
song
To thy Redeemer!—yea, it poured along
In most melodious energy of praise,
To God, the Saviour, he of ancient days,
The heart and language rising with the
theme,
Till praise gushed forth one living,
glowing stream!
Then from thy lips the thrilling language
fell,
"Glory to Him who raised my soul from
hell!"
—Baptized in tears was many a cheek that
day,
As **Sarah Cresson** told her checquered
way.
'T was her last gospel labour here of love,
—
Mercy soon gathered her to praise above.

Of polished manners and of graceful
mien,
Lovely in life, was **Mary Morton** seen;
Each native talent sanctified by grace,
Was kept, obedient, in its proper place.
Not quick to offer, cautious still to try,

As Gideon did his fleece, both wet and
dry.
Like leaven working where no eye could
view,
Her spirit wrestled for the heavenly dew;
She dug for water in a weary soil,
Till bubbling life-springs recompensed her
toil.
—As gently passed the fleeting breath
away,
Retortive memory brought her youthful
day,
And one fond look back on the past she
flung,
While "Oh, my mother!" trembled on her
tongue;
Then the freed spirit passed—and
beauteous lay
The rifled casket, lovely in decay!

Widows and orphans ye may mourn
indeed!
Who now shall clothe you, who the
hungry feed?
Yes! show your garments, tattered ones,
and say,
These **Sansom** gave us in a wintry day.
From the bleak storm she clothed the
shivering frame,
When sickness pressed with healing
cordials came;
When age went tottering with no hand to
save,
She gave the crutch supporting to the
grave!
No cold philosophy was her's, to dream
Of Bentham's theory or Malthus's scheme,

As the heart prompted, the concurring
hand
Obeyed, instinctively, each kind
command.
When streams of suffering ran beside her
door,
The bitter waters lost their nauseous
power;
The prophet's salt she in the current threw,
And soft and sweet the changing waters
grew.
Careful her Master's bounty to bestow,
A faithful stewardship of gifts to show,
That she might hear that language at the
close,
"To me ye did it, as ye did to those!"

A pillar of the church, erect and strong,
Swayed by no friendship to the church's
wrong;
Unwarped, unmoved, sound to the very
core,
And rendered firmer by the weight he
bore;
An honest watchman the alarm to sound,
When foes were sowing tares within our
ground,—
Or rootless plants luxuriously would shoot
In spreading branches, and produce no
fruit,—
Was **Evans**. Oft the archers' bows were
bent,
To turn the veteran from his firm intent;
Their malice moved not, and their threats
were vain,
Fixed at his post determined to remain:
And when at last the final goal was won,

Death's message found him with his
armour on;
No oilless lamp to trim, no loins to gird,
Ready to enter at the Bridegroom's word,
Where his loved **Hannah**, earlier called
away,
Was his forerunner to the realms of day.

So too our **Sheppard**,[\[4\]](#) when she
heard the cry,
Her wings expanding sought her home on
high;
One thought upon a faithful sufferer cast,
Told her own hopes—then to her audit
past.

Amid the terrors of that evil hour,
When Infidelity put forth its power,
Though meek of manners and of gentle
heart,
Jane Bettle played a Christian soldier's
part.
Though courteous, firm,—unwavering,
though kind,
Pupil of Christ, he disciplined her mind.
Secluded long from active service here,
Yet bearing burdens in her proper sphere,
In humble waiting she was faithful found,
Until her fetters were in love unbound.
Her youthful **Edward**, bud of promise
rare,
Was early called to bloom in regions fair;
Another cord, strong though unseen, to
move
The heart to seek a resting place above.

Allen, when all around was clothed in
night,
Passed from earth's darkness to eternal
light.
Oh, what a blessed change to thee was
given,
To sleep in Jesus and to wake in heaven;
Leave thy worn vestments with their
earthly stain,
A spotless robe of righteousness to gain!

Ye who my being gave,—ye too have
flown,
To join the ransomed round the eternal
throne.
—The venerable sire, as death drew near,
Saw the vale awful, but devoid of fear;
He whom he loved was near him in that
hour,
Death had no terrors and the grave no
power.
Before thee, mother, rose a "brilliant
path,"—
For thee thy Saviour had no looks of
wrath.
Oh, ye had owned Him long, and at the
last
His arm supported as ye Jordan passed!

Thus one by one, in quick succession,
go
Those who have laboured in the church
below!
We dare not murmur as we kiss the rod,
Thou art our Helper, save thy church, O
God!

Thine is the cause, thy frowns we dare not
shun,
In earth and heaven alike, thy will be
done!

Tell me, my Old Arm Chair, when thou
wert young,
Were Quaker parlours with gilt pictures
hung?
Did any Quaker to his image fall,
A household idol placed against the wall?
Ah, well might honest **Catharine** cry to
pride,
"Abomination!" as she turned aside.
—But times are altered; splendid
mansions glow,
And gilded mirrors *humble Quakers* show.
With Turkey carpets are their parlours
spread,
While silken curtains hang about their
bed!
What contradiction!—grave the dame and
sire;
Gorgeous their dwelling,—simple their
attire!
Their children moulding to the place they
dwell,
In London fashions, Paris manners, swell,
—
While parents scarcely wish to set them
free—
For what they won't restrain they love to
see.

Are there no worthies now to fill the
place,

Of those, victorious, who have run their
race?
Are we deserted?—has all merit flown,
And must the church in helpless anguish
moan?
Oh, no! the grace that made them what
they were,
A living remnant in due measure share;
And haply they on whom their mantles fit,
May where the ancients sat, in judgment
sit.

Faith, give me power to see a brighter
day,
When all these "letting things" shall pass
away;
When the convulsion which has now
begun,
Shall pause in silence, all its purpose
done;
When the oppressors of the seed, shall
wear
The mask no longer, all their acts laid
bare;
When chaff and cheat shall to the wind be
doomed,
And dross and stubble be by fire
consumed;
When to the world the worldly part is
given;
When the redeemed shall closer walk with
Heaven;
When to our Zion shall the weary come,
Like "doves to windows," pressing to their
home.
Oh, haste the day, when through his power
divine,

The Father's light around his church shall
shine!

Many there are whose prayers arise for
this;
Whose greatest joy would be in Zion's
bliss;
Whose morning breathing, and whose
evening prayer
Is that the Lord would place his glory
there.

—What though a worldly spirit has crept
in,
That fain the kingdom through new ways
would win,
Scorning the narrow path our fathers trod,
And circling round would pass the cross
and rod—

Yet they who look from Pisgah's height
can see,
Such by-paths lead away from Calvary,—
While they who seek in empty forms for
bliss,
Will grasp at shadows and the substance
miss.

—No, no!—as ancient **Pennock**[\[5\]](#) clearly
saw,

Still with this people shall abide the law;
Still shall the testimony here be found,—
Still sons and daughters to the altar bound.
The Lord himself his attributes shall take;
Again shall order out of chaos break;
Then shall the church in rapturous
numbers sing,
And shout victorious as she owns her
King;

While those who seek to draw her from
the way,
Themselves shall lose in errors paths
astray!

NOTES.

Note 1. Sarah Harrison was aunt to Jane Snowdon. When on a religious visit in Great Britain, she felt her mind engaged to speak to George III. When she commenced addressing him, he took off his hat, and remained uncovered during her communication. She died in Philadelphia, the 29th of Twelfth month, 1812, aged 76; a minister 55 years.

Note 2. Samuel Emlen, felt concerned often to look up the sick, weak and halt of the flock; and for this purpose, in the latter part of his life, he kept a one horse chair, in which he rode about "doing good:" in allusion to which practice, he sometimes said, he "earned his bread by jobbing." He died the 30th of Twelfth month, 1799, aged 75.

Note 3. David Bacon and descendants.—William Wilson, an elder of Philadelphia Monthly Meeting.—Sarah Proctor Wilson, a minister of the Southern District Monthly Meeting.

Note 4. Catharine Sheppard, an elder of the Northern District Monthly Meeting, died the 15th of Twelfth month, 1842, aged 80 years. The following lines appeared a few days after in one of the daily papers, on the occasion of her death.

Sleep, mother, sleep, for thy work is
now done,
Thy course is accomplished, the victory
won!
Doubts and fears can no longer arise in
thy path,
Nor tempest-cloud hover with threatening
wrath.

Sleep, mother, sleep! our protector and
guide!
Though we fain would have turned all
Death's arrows aside;

Though we clung to thee fondly, and
watched every breath,
Thy spirit unnoticed departed with Death.

Ah, cruel destroyer!—But cease ye, and
hear
What sounds of sweet melody break on
the ear!
'Tis the voice of rejoicing, oh, listen the
sound,
That a prisoner of hope from the earth is
unbound!

There!—hearken once more to the full-
swelling strain,
The words of rejoicing we even may
name;
They say, "Come up here, see the bride of
the Lamb,
That stands by the throne of the mighty I
AM!"

"Come home, mother, come!"—Ah, how
vain is that cry,
The home of the righteous is fixed in the
sky!
Earth's treasures wax old, its attractions all
wither,
The cry of the ransomed is, "Come ye up
hither!"

Note 5. Caleb Pennock, upwards of 90 years of age, recently addressed the young men of his Monthly Meeting in a very remarkable manner, expressing his belief that the doctrines of this Society would not be suffered to fall.

*** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE ARM CHAIR

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